

Atonement Theories

Ransom Theory



- The Ransom Theory of atonement is one of the earliest explanations of Christ's work on the cross. In this view, humanity is considered to have fallen into the captivity of sin and Satan as a result of the Fall. Jesus' death is seen as a ransom paid to Satan to free humanity from this bondage. Since humanity could not pay the debt themselves, Jesus took their place, offering His life as a ransom to liberate them from the devil's control. The Ransom Theory portrays the devil as holding humanity hostage, and Jesus' sacrifice as the

necessary payment to restore humans to God.

- Ransom Theory was dominant in the early Christian church, particularly in the writings of Church Fathers like Origen and Gregory of Nyssa. However, it has since become less central in modern theology. While no mainstream Christian denomination exclusively subscribes to the Ransom Theory today, its themes are sometimes found in Eastern Orthodox thought and continue to influence broader Christian understandings of salvation.

Christus Victor

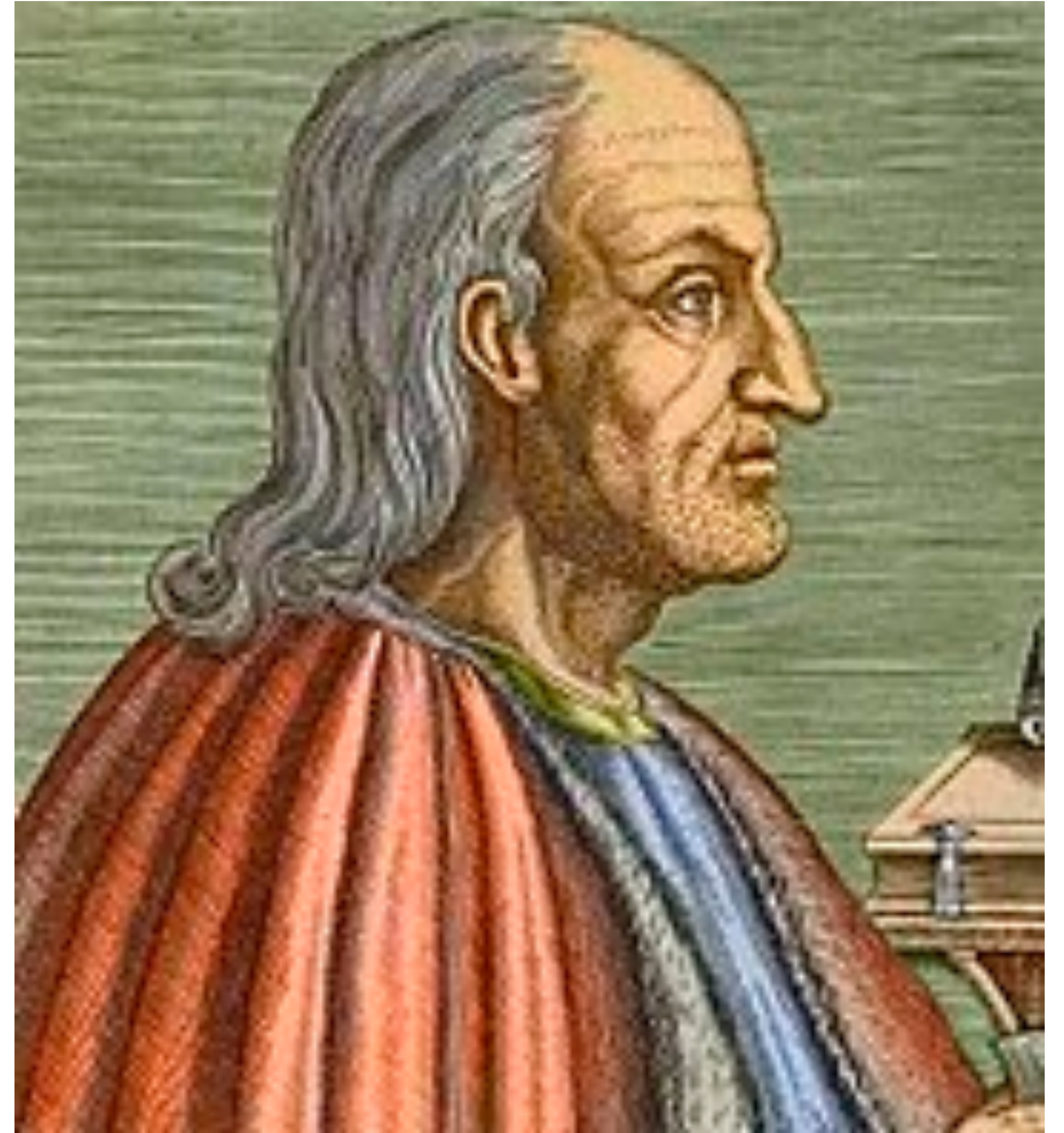


- The Christus Victor model is closely related to the Ransom Theory but emphasizes Christ's victory over the powers of sin, death, and the devil. In this view, humanity is trapped in a cosmic struggle between good and evil, and Jesus' death and resurrection signify God's ultimate triumph over these forces. Rather than focusing on Jesus as a ransom paid, this theory emphasizes His role as a conqueror who defeats the powers of darkness and liberates humanity from the bondage of sin and death. The resurrection is a pivotal

moment, confirming Christ's victory and signaling the renewal of creation.

- Christus Victor is strongly associated with Eastern Orthodox Christianity, where it is one of the dominant atonement models. It also holds a place in Lutheranism and has been gaining renewed interest among some Protestant theologians as an alternative to Penal Substitution. It resonates with believers who emphasize the cosmic and restorative aspects of salvation.

Satisfaction Theory



- Satisfaction Theory was formulated by Anselm of Canterbury in the 11th century. It posits that humanity owes a debt of honor to God due to sin, which dishonors God and creates a rupture in the divine order. Humanity is incapable of repaying this debt, but Jesus, both divine and human, satisfies the debt on their behalf. Christ's sacrificial death restores the order of creation by paying what is owed to God, thereby allowing humanity to be reconciled with God. This model

emphasizes the justice of God and the necessity of reparation for sin.

- Satisfaction Theory is prominent in Roman Catholicism, where it forms the foundation of their understanding of atonement, particularly in the context of the sacrificial and redemptive work of Christ. This theory is also influential in some Protestant traditions, especially in classical Anglicanism, though it is often presented in modified forms alongside other atonement models.

Penal Substitution Theory



- Penal Substitution Theory is a development of Anselm's Satisfaction Theory but focuses more on the legal consequences of sin. According to this theory, humanity deserves punishment (penalty) for their sins, and divine justice requires this punishment to be carried out. Jesus, in His perfect obedience, takes the place of sinners, bearing the punishment that humanity deserves. His death on the cross satisfies God's justice, allowing believers to be forgiven and reconciled with God. This model emphasizes themes of justice, punishment, and substitution.
- Penal Substitution is most commonly associated with Reformed and Evangelical traditions, including many Calvinist, Baptist, and conservative Protestant denominations. It is the dominant atonement theory in these circles, where the emphasis on legal metaphors, such as punishment and acquittal, fits well with their doctrinal focus on the sovereignty and justice of God. Some critics, however, view Penal Substitution as too focused on punishment and not enough on other aspects of Christ's work.

Mirror/Scapegoat Theory



- The Mimetic Theory, developed by René Girard, interprets the atonement through the lens of human violence and scapegoating. Girard argues that human societies are marked by mimetic (imitative) rivalry, which leads to violence and the creation of scapegoats to resolve communal tension. Jesus' death, according to this theory, exposes and breaks the cycle of violence and scapegoating. Rather than being a sacrifice demanded by God, Jesus is the innocent victim of human violence, and His resurrection reveals the futility of that violence. Jesus unmask the scapegoat mechanism, offering a path to reconciliation without violence.
- Mimetic Theory is not officially embraced by any major Christian denomination but has gained traction among theologians who are critical of traditional atonement models that involve divine violence. Some contemporary Christian theologians, especially those in peace and justice movements, find Girard's approach compelling as it offers a non-violent understanding of the atonement. It has found some resonance in progressive Christian circles and among theologians who emphasize the transformative and reconciliatory aspects of Christ's work.

A Contemporary United Methodist Understanding of Atonement:

**From Gregory Jones' book, Embodying
Forgiveness: A Theological Analysis,**

- For Jones, as for Wesley, the problem of human sin is the loss and failure of humans' relationships with God and one another.
- 1. Being made "in the image of God" means that the Trinitarian God has endowed human beings with the capacity for relationships. The relationships of which we humans are capable are predicated upon our being free, morally responsible, self-aware, persons who are deeply loved by God. Out of the richness of God's love, we are able to enter into loving relationships with one another. These relationships are to be realized fully within communities characterized by justice and peace.
- 2. Sin is a multifaceted refusal to live according to God's image. Sin grows out of fear, faithlessness, and greed. It is expressed as a "will to power." Violence is the ultimate manifestation of a will to power, but every form of manipulation, oppression, injustice, and exploitation manifests it.

- 3. Sin makes healthy relationships impossible. It breaks relationships in the immediate sense by destroying trust and mutuality. More tragically, sin destroys the foundations of relationships. It isolates us in "our own world," where a realistic and healthy sense of self is sabotaged by self-loathing and self-justification. Sin brings guilt and a desire to judge others. It turns us into victims and victimizers. By making it impossible for us to "live with ourselves, " sin prohibits us from living successfully with others. It causes us to be afraid of God and one another. It makes us despise God and one another. Sin reduces life to a struggle for survival/ supremacy. War, racism, economic injustice, criminal behavior, and many manifestations of pathological distress are "outward and visible" signs of an "inward and spiritual" disease. Individually and collectively, our human "face", becomes a perverse distortion of God's image.

- 4. Sin becomes a part of the "original" human condition by habituation. Violence and other manifestations of a will to power become the "norm" for human behavior and culture. Justice ceases to be a positive force and is reduced to a cynical attempt to balance the scales of suffering and retribution. Religion is co-opted by the powerful as a means of aggression and self-justification. It is embraced by the powerless as sop and as an indulgence in self-pity. We humans enter into pseudo-relationships based upon agreements of mutual exploitation. We flock together with those like us in order to create a common defense against "others." Power and materialism become idolatrous substitutes or relationships with God and one other. The future is held captive by the past.

- B. Atonement breaks the power of sin. Referring to Barth, Jones offers several thoughts on how God forgives sin through Christ's death and resurrection.
- 1. Barth submitted that in the death of Jesus, "the righteous judge" allowed himself to be judged by unrighteous human beings.
- a. Because we are trapped within cycles of violence and retribution, we humans pronounced a judgement of condemnation against Jesus. Our judgement was that Jesus "deserved to die." The machinations of Pilate and the bloodthirsty religious leaders made Jesus' trial a classic manifestation of the "will to power." It was a spectacle in which Jesus refused to participate, however. The violent crucifixion of Jesus constituted the ultimate expression of humanity's will to power.

- b. Our judgement of Jesus turned out to be a judgement of ourselves. God allowed the "judgement" to go forward to death, but reversed its verdict through the resurrection. God judged humanity's judgement of Jesus and pronounced it false, evil and invalid. Humanity was thereby judged. The crucifixion and resurrection of Jesus fulfilled the Old Testament principle of "Tochachah," the aspect of forgiveness by which the guilty are made aware of their offense.

- c. God's judgement of humanity was not a judgement of condemnation, but a judgement of grace. It was a judgement intended not to punish, but to save us. As such, it broke the cycle between violence and retribution. God did not exact retribution by returning violence and death for violence and death. God responded to the violence and death of the cross by granting life. Jesus was "avenged," not by the death of his enemies, but by his own resurrection to new life. We who made ourselves enemies of Christ are forgiven through the invitation to share in the new life of the resurrection. The cross and resurrection judged us with grace by revealing our depravity and offering us an opportunity to break free from captivity to depravity. It was "judgement" in the sense of disclosing our depravity. It was "grace" in the sense of offering us new life in God's Kingdom.

- 2. Jesus forgave sin by refusing the role of victim or victimizer, thereby breaking the cycle between violence and retribution.
- a. The violence committed against Jesus was wholly unjustified. It made him a "justified" victim. Jesus had every right to claim "victim status" and demand retribution. Instead, he willingly lay down his life, not as an act of capitulation or self-pity, but as an act of integrity and "self-differentiation." 4 Jesus refused to "play the power game" and defined himself apart from humanity's "will to power." By doing so, Jesus truly "turned the other cheek" and proved to be the victor rather than the victim.
- b. As a "justified" victim, Jesus had every right to demand retribution. In fact, the Old Testament principle of equal retribution gave Jesus the right to take "eye for an eye, life for life" vengeance upon his enemies. By his refusal to do so, Jesus broke the cycle between violence and revenge and refused the role of victimizer.

- 3. Jesus broke the ties between past reality and future necessity. Humanity's sin against Jesus did not bring inevitable punishment. By the power of resurrection, Jesus' death was transformed into a saving event. We guilty humans are invited to experience transformation by which we are prepared for life in God's kingdom.

- a. The past is neither denied nor forgotten. It is a part of God's judgment of grace upon us. The cross does not represent a total "break" with the past, but an end to our captivity of the past.
- b. The "break" with the past comes at the point of our not being subject to a judgment of condemnation because of past sins. We are forgiven in the sense of being offered a bright and promising future in God's Kingdom.

- IV. Embodying Forgiveness:
Forgiveness as a Way of Life.
- A. Jones rejects what he calls
"therapeutic" forgiveness. By this,
he means an understanding of
forgiveness that emphasizes our
need for relief from guilt. Following
the precedent of Wesley, Jones
insists that forgiveness should
make a difference in our lives, not
just make us feel better about
ourselves.

- B. For Jones, forgiveness is a reality into which people of faith must live. Forgiveness is an opportunity to escape vicious cycles of victimization and victim-hood, violence and retribution. Forgiveness is an opportunity to escape our captivity to the sins of the past and experience restored relationships with God and one another.
- 1 . Forgiveness is costly. Christ's forgiveness of humanity was costly and painful. Our forgiveness of one another is costly. It can be painful. Forgiveness doesn't "forget" the past as though it never happened. It refuses to be controlled by the injustices of the past.

- 2. The ability to truly forgive is only possible when one is a mature person."6 Growth toward maturity is growth into forgiveness. The ability to forgive is a large part of what Wesley meant by being made "perfect in love."
- 3. Forgiveness is not a one-sided affair. The principle of "Tochachah" is evident in the cross's judgement of humanity. It is always embodied in true forgiveness. True forgiveness gives a real opportunity for repentance. Jones sees the Church as a community in which the principle of Tochachah is practiced individually and corporately as a matter of redemptive discipline.

- 3. Forgiveness is realized fully only through repentance. God's forgiveness is not dependent upon our repentance, but our realization of God's forgiveness is dependent upon repentance. Our forgiveness of one another also depends upon our willingness to repent of the behaviors and attitudes by which we hurt one another.
- a. In relation to God, the necessity of repentance falls entirely upon us.
- b. In relationships between "equals," the necessity of repentance almost always falls upon both parties.
- c. In relationships where one person or group of people have most of the power and the power is abused upon others, the necessity of repentance falls primarily upon the powerful. Examples include child abuse and historic white racism.

- C. Jones struggles with the question of whether there are or should be limits to forgiveness. He cites the Jewish holocaust as an example of something that perhaps can't be forgiven.
- 1. Jones repudiates "cheap grace" as a "cover" for such evils.
- 2. He acknowledges the fact that many people apparently are unrepentant. He notes the historic doctrine of hell takes the destiny of the unrepentant seriously.
- 3. Jones concludes, however, that forgiveness is limited only by humanity's ability to accept it and extend it, not by God's desire to withhold it. He notes that because forgiveness flows from the Being of the Triune God, its universality is not in question. Jones sides with Wesley in upholding the "character" of God as a being of love and grace. This agrees with the classic Methodist proposition that we are "forgiven into forgiveness." Therefore, our ability to forgive each other is limited not by the severity of the offenses we commit against each other, but by our ability to accept the grace of God.

- D. Jones returns to the realization that forgiveness is not easy or painless. He notes that in terms of retributive justice, it is outrageous and impossible. As an expression of the Being of God the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit, however, it is an eternal verity.
- 1. As such, forgiveness is a reality into which Christians can only grow over time. Forgiveness is not a single act which, once committed, is finished. It is a way of life.
- 2. The embodiment of forgiveness is the mission of the Church. It anticipates and prepares persons for the Kingdom of God. The Kingdom of God awaits its fulfillment at the "end.,, Nevertheless, God's Kingdom exists now whenever and wherever genuine forgiveness is pursued and practiced.
- 3. The embodiment of forgiveness is much more than a mere imitation of Jesus' example. It is the sharing of Jesus' resurrected life through the Holy Spirit. The embodiment of forgiveness is participation in the very life of the Triune God.